

Charles Proxy

Complete Installation & Setup

Beginner guide - from download to first use

Objective

By the end of this manual, you should be able to install the tool, validate the installation, perform the first functional use and recognize common errors. Do not skip validation steps: they confirm that each stage actually worked.

Before you start

This is a desktop application. You may also need access credentials to a non-production system for the first functional validation.

Official download and documentation

<https://www.charlesproxy.com/>

<https://www.charlesproxy.com/documentation/>

<https://www.charlesproxy.com/download/>

Attention

Use only test environments, accounts and devices when a tool can capture traffic, run scans, modify infrastructure or access data. In corporate environments, follow your organization policies.

Open the correct terminal

On Windows, use CMD or PowerShell. On macOS and Linux, use Terminal. Run commands exactly as shown and press Enter after each line.

Windows - step by step

Download the official Windows installer from the product page, run it and accept only the components needed for your QA environment.

Launch Charles, confirm the local proxy port and configure SSL Proxying only for systems you are authorized to inspect.

macOS - step by step

Download the official macOS package for your architecture and install it according to the vendor instructions.

Launch Charles Proxy from the installed application/package.

Linux - step by step

Use the official Linux package/repository when the product supports Linux; if Linux is not supported, use a supported OS.

Launch Charles Proxy from the installed application/package.

Validate the installation

1. Open Charles Proxy and confirm the version in its About/Help screen.

Commands and configuration

1. Launch Charles, confirm the local proxy port and configure SSL Proxying only for systems you are authorized to inspect.

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PATH, environment variables and a new terminal

When an installer adds an executable to PATH or you configure a variable such as JAVA_HOME/ANDROID_HOME, close the old terminal and open a new CMD/PowerShell. Then repeat the version command. If multiple versions are installed, use where <command> on Windows or which <command> on macOS/Linux to identify the executable being used. Do not remove PATH entries without understanding their origin.

Create a safe test folder

For the first tests, use a simple folder with no production files, for example C:\Projects\qa-lab or ~/qa-lab. This makes generated files, virtual environments, logs and configuration easier to identify.

First use / functional test

1. Launch Charles, confirm the local proxy port and configure SSL Proxying only for systems you are authorized to inspect.

Expected result

Charles opens and captures authorized HTTP traffic.

Troubleshooting

- Read the terminal error before repeating commands. Check PATH/environment variables, runtime version, permissions, system architecture and whether a new terminal was opened after environment changes.
- Command not found: confirm the installation directory is on PATH and open a new terminal.
- Wrong version: check whether another older runtime or executable appears earlier on PATH.
- Permission denied: use a user-writable project directory and follow the vendor permission guidance; do not blindly run everything as administrator/root.
- Corporate proxy/firewall: configure the package manager/tool according to your organization network policy rather than disabling security controls.

Final checklist

- Official download and documentation
- Windows - step by step / macOS - step by step / Linux - step by step
- Validate the installation
- First use / functional test
- Expected result
- Troubleshooting

Installation validated. Keep this manual for reinstallations, onboarding and troubleshooting.